

test drive ■ start up

How we Test

It looks good and the technology is glitzy, but does it do the job?

The Digital Media Test & Research Centre (DMTRC) conducts a series of elaborate tests to evaluate the merit of each hardware and software product. To ensure that our readers have all the information they need to make an informed buying decision, engineers at DMTRC evaluate and review the latest hardware, software and technology services in accordance with the most up-to-date evaluation processes and methodologies used around the world.

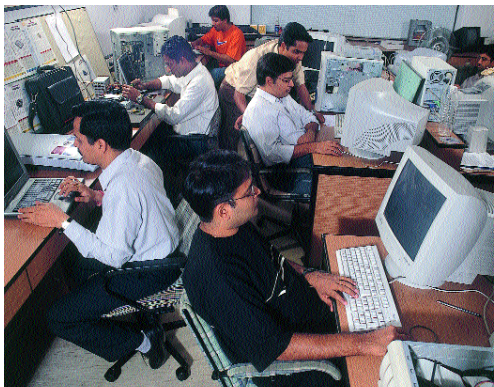
Comparison Tests

We use a dual rating system, the first of which is applied to the Comparison Tests in which we compare the performance of products within a particular category.

Each product is evaluated under different parameters such as performance, value for money, features, warranty and support, etc.

Weightages are then applied to the various test parameters according to their importance for that particular category of products.

These weightages are then used to arrive at an overall grade for each individual product. An overall grade of A+, therefore, indicates that the product is close to perfection.



The Awards

Digit awards outstanding products by selecting a Best Performance and Best Value winner in each comparison test. The winner of the Best Performance Award will be the product that scored the highest in the performance segment of our tests.

This award represents the best performing product in our tests and doesn't factor in any other parameter such as value for money, features, support, etc. The winner of the Best Value Award will be the product that scores the highest in our value for money parameter which is derived

taking into account the ratio of a product's performance and features to its price. The product winning this award offers good performance at a great price.

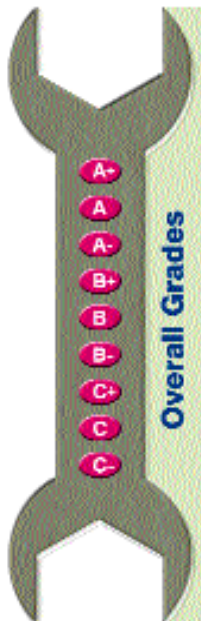


In Bazaar

The second part of the rating system is used to evaluate individual hardware and software products in the Bazaar section. The evaluation covers parameters such as performance, ease of use, value for money and the build quality/features of the product in question and then arrives at an overall rating.

Here each of these parameters is given a weightage of 25 per cent and is rated on a scale of 5, which is represented by arrows (▶).

The greater the number of arrows, the better the product. This simple five-point rating system is designed to give you an easy-to-interpret assessment of a product. For example, a product that receives an overall score of five arrows signifies an outstanding buy!

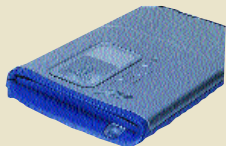


The 5-point Rating System used in Bazaar	
▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶	Excellent: a brilliant combination of price, performance and features—far beyond expectations
▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶	Good: a good buy, better than most products in its category
▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶	Average: reasonably competent but nothing spectacular about the product
▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶	Mediocre: does not live up to expectations, needs improvement in many areas
▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶	Poor: has serious drawbacks and needs improvement before it can be used for its target application



In Test this Mo

This month we bring you a comprehensive, end-to-end solution for your storage needs. We've benchmarked, evaluated and tortured IDE hard disk drives, 7 IDE drives, 11 CD-RW drives, a set of 11 external storage devices ranging from external CD-RW drives to Zip drives and portable hard



disks. This includes some of the world's fastest DVD CD-RW drives, a 200 GB monster hard disk and a host of USB 2.0 compliant external storage devices offering capacities ranging from 250 MB to 60 GB! Out of which one is the best suited to your specific needs and applications.

In the Bazaar section we have the newest offerings on the processor and motherboard front with the speedy Athlon XP 2600+ and the formidable MSI Ultra, featuring a host of technologies such as Bluetooth, AGP 8X and the KT 400 chipset for Athlon processors.

On the software front we review SuSE 8.0 Professional—find out if it gives you reason enough to venture into the world of Linux. We also bring you an exclusive preview of the new version of one of the most popular 3D rendering applications, 3ds max Release 4. We delve into its enhancements and embellishments and give you the lowdown on whether it is worth upgrading to.

